ROOTEDWITHKHETHIWE

# School of the Prophets

FOUNDATIONS



LESSON 03 / 05

# Daniel the Interpreter

*Search a matter with humility*

SCRIPTURE / TEACHING / PRACTICE

# Daniel the Interpreter

**READ IN WEB • Daniel 2:14–30 · Daniel 7:15–16, 28 · Genesis 40:5–8**

## Daniel’s first move

In Daniel 2, the king’s demand puts lives at risk. Daniel asks for time, goes to his companions and invites them to seek mercy from God. When the mystery is disclosed, he blesses God before returning to the king. Trace his actions in order. Ask what changes when you read the scene as a story of dependence and shared prayer. Daniel’s answer before the king directs attention to the God who reveals mysteries.

## Receiving and understanding

Daniel 7 shows Daniel disturbed by his own vision and asking what it means. By the end he keeps the matter in his heart. Compare him with Joseph in Genesis 40:8, who also directs attention to God when asked about interpretation. These passages give us room to record a dream, acknowledge that it affected us, ask for understanding and leave questions open.

## Read the whole dream first

Record the setting, people, action, emotional shifts and ending before circling individual images. Ask what the dreamer associates with an image and what is happening in her life. A locked gate at a childhood home may evoke something different from a locked gate at work. A possible reading should help explain the sequence and tone. Keep a separate note for recent experiences that might have supplied the dream’s imagery.

# Practice and reflection

### Practice · The envelope at the station

A woman dreams she is at a station with a sealed envelope. She tries to run toward a train, but her sister tells her to look at the ticket. The train on the ticket leaves an hour later. She sits down and feels relieved. The woman has recently been rushing to submit several applications.

**Observation.** Write what happens without explaining it. Where does the feeling change? What detail corrects her first assumption? **Possible interpretation.** The dream could reflect pressure to hurry or invite reflection on timing. The recent applications also give the scene an ordinary source of imagery. **Response.** She could check her real deadlines and bring her anxiety to prayer. The dream itself gives her no basis to miss a real deadline.

### Practise humility with someone else’s story

Ask permission before sharing someone’s dream. Let the dreamer describe what felt important to her. Offer a possible reading as a possibility, then give her space to disagree. If an interpretation would pressure someone into a consequential decision, pause, weigh it with trusted counsel and respect their freedom to decide.

### Journal and pray

What do I know from the dream itself? What have I added from my own associations? What question would help me understand the dream more carefully?

God of wisdom, help me listen carefully and speak humbly. Give me patience with mystery and compassion for the person whose story I am hearing. Amen.

**SOURCE • The Interpreter, “There Is a God in Heaven,” “Prayer Before Presumption” and “Ask for Understanding.”**

# Reading dream symbols

READ THE IMAGE IN CONTEXT • A FIELD GUIDE

## Colours

**White** may suggest cleansing or righteousness. Isaiah 1:18 contrasts scarlet with snow-white, and Revelation 19:8 explains the bride's bright, clean linen as righteous acts. **Scarlet** can evoke sin in Isaiah 1:18, yet the scarlet cord identifies the household to be spared in Joshua 2:18–21. **Purple** can suggest royalty or status, as in Esther 8:15. **Green** can call to mind flourishing or nourishment, as in Psalm 23:2. Ask whether the colour stood out, what it belonged to, and what it means in the dreamer's own setting.

## Numbers

**Three** marks three days in the cupbearer's dream (Genesis 40:9–13). **Seven** can evoke completion or rest in the creation week (Genesis 2:2–3), while Pharaoh's sevens represent years (Genesis 41:25–32). **Twelve** can call to mind God's people and their communal identity (Revelation 21:12–14). **Forty** can call to mind a period of testing or preparation (Matthew 4:1–2). Consider a literal quantity, date or time first. Hold the unit open unless the story gives you reason to name it.

## Common images

**Doors** may suggest access, opportunity or a boundary. Compare the open door in 1 Corinthians 16:9 with the shut door in Matthew 25:10–12. **Water** can suggest nourishment or refreshment (Psalm 23:2) and can also appear as a danger (Psalm 69:1–2). **A lamp** may suggest guidance (Psalm 119:105). **Clothing** may suggest role, identity or change (Esther 8:15 and Zechariah 3:3–5). **A house** may bring family, belonging or foundations to mind (Matthew 7:24–27). Ask what the image does in the scene and how the dreamer responds to it.

## Try it · Three keys at a door

Imagine seeing three keys beside a closed door at your childhood home. What changes if the door feels protective rather than frightening? Could the three keys simply be the three keys you carry every day? Write two plausible readings and identify the detail that would help you weigh them. Keep the whole dream, the dreamer's associations and the emotional movement in view.

# Scripture readings

### Daniel 2:14–30

**14** Then Daniel returned answer with counsel and prudence to Arioch the captain of the king's guard, who had gone out to kill the wise men of Babylon.

**15** He answered Arioch the king's captain, "Why is the decree so urgent from the king?" Then Arioch made the thing known to Daniel.

**16** Daniel went in, and desired of the king that he would appoint him a time, and he would show the king the interpretation.

**17** Then Daniel went to his house and made the thing known to Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah, his companions:

**18** that they would desire mercies of the God of heaven concerning this secret, that Daniel and his companions would not perish with the rest of the wise men of Babylon.

**19** Then the secret was revealed to Daniel in a vision of the night. Then Daniel blessed the God of heaven.

**20** Daniel answered, "Blessed be the name of God forever and ever; for wisdom and might are his.

**21** He changes the times and the seasons. He removes kings and sets up kings. He gives wisdom to the wise, and knowledge to those who have understanding.

**22** He reveals the deep and secret things. He knows what is in the darkness, and the light dwells with him.

**23** I thank you and praise you, O God of my fathers, who have given me wisdom and might, and have now made known to me what we desired of you; for you have made known to us the king's matter."

**24** Therefore Daniel went in to Arioch, whom the king had appointed to destroy the wise men of Babylon. He went and said this to him: "Don't destroy the wise men of Babylon. Bring me in before the king, and I will show to the king the interpretation."

**25** Then Arioch brought in Daniel before the king in haste, and said this to him: "I have found a man of the children of the captivity of Judah who will make known to the king the interpretation."

**26** The king answered Daniel, whose name was Belteshazzar, "Are you able to make known to me the dream which I have seen, and its interpretation?"

**27** Daniel answered before the king, and said, "The secret which the king has demanded can't be shown to the king by wise men, enchanters, magicians, or soothsayers;

**28** but there is a God in heaven who reveals secrets, and he has made known to King Nebuchadnezzar what will be in the latter days. Your dream and the visions of your head on your bed are these:

**29** "As for you, O king, your thoughts came on your bed, what should happen hereafter; and he who reveals secrets has made known to you what will happen.

**30** But as for me, this secret is not revealed to me for any wisdom that I have more than any living, but to the intent that the interpretation may be made known to the king, and that you may know the thoughts of your heart.

# Scripture readings continued

### Daniel 7:15–16, 28

**15** “As for me, Daniel, my spirit was grieved within my body, and the visions of my head troubled me.

**16** I came near to one of those who stood by, and asked him the truth concerning all this. “So he told me, and made me know the interpretation of the things.

**28** “Here is the end of the matter. As for me, Daniel, my thoughts troubled me greatly, and my face was changed in me; but I kept the matter in my heart.”

### Genesis 40:5–8

**5** They both dreamed a dream, each man his dream, in one night, each man according to the interpretation of his dream, the cup bearer and the baker of the king of Egypt, who were bound in the prison.

**6** Joseph came in to them in the morning, and saw them, and saw that they were sad.

**7** He asked Pharaoh’s officers who were with him in custody in his master’s house, saying, “Why do you look so sad today?”

**8** They said to him, “We have dreamed a dream, and there is no one who can interpret it.” Joseph said to them, “Don’t interpretations belong to God? Please tell it to me.”